

COGNITIVE BEHAVIORAL THERAPY (CBT) – SESSION 2

Homework Review, Deeper Formulation & Identifying Key Thoughts

Fictional Educational Example — Full Detailed

SESSION INFORMATION

Client:	RK (35 y/o Male, Software Engineer)	Therapist:	Dr. A.
Session #:	2 of 16	Focus:	Homework review + Formulation + Key NATs

PRE-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

Client completed the daily diary homework consistently (7 entries). Clear patterns visible: highest anxiety in the evenings while preparing for next day's work and during/after meetings. Dominant negative automatic thoughts center around being judged as incompetent. Today's plan: Review homework in detail, expand the formulation using the 5-area model, identify 2–3 key negative automatic thoughts, and begin gentle cognitive restructuring on one of them.

SESSION START & MOOD CHECK

Therapist: Good morning, RK. How has your week been overall, and how are you feeling right now on a scale of 0 to 10?

Client: Around 5. Better than last week in some ways — I slept a bit more — but I still had two very anxious days before important meetings.

HOMEWORK REVIEW – DAILY DIARY

Therapist: Thank you for bringing the diary. Let's go through it together. Can you tell me about one or two entries that stood out to you?

Client: On Tuesday evening while preparing slides, my mood dropped to 3. The thought that kept coming was "If these numbers are wrong, they'll think I don't know what I'm doing." I ended up checking the slides until 1 AM.

Therapist: That's very useful. So the situation was preparing slides, the thought was about being seen as incompetent, mood dropped sharply, and the behavior was over-checking until very late. Do you see how the thought drove the behavior and made you more tired the next day?

Client: Yes, I can see it clearly now when I look at the diary.

(Therapist and client review 2–3 more entries together and identify recurring patterns: evenings, meetings, and situations involving evaluation by seniors.)

DEEPENING THE FORMULATION (5-Area Model)

Therapist: Last session we used a simple thought-feeling-behavior cycle. Today let's expand it into the full 5-area model that we often use in CBT. This helps us see the bigger picture.

Therapist draws/writes the 5 areas on paper:

1. Situation / Trigger
2. Thoughts (including images)
3. Emotions
4. Physical sensations
5. Behaviors

Therapist: Let's fill this together using Tuesday's situation as an example.

Situation: Preparing quarterly slides alone in the evening

Thoughts: "If these numbers are wrong, they'll think I don't know what I'm doing. They'll finally realize I'm not as good as they think."

Emotions: Anxiety (8/10), Shame (7/10)

Physical sensations: Racing heart, tight chest, sweaty palms, jaw clenching

Behaviors: Over-checking every number repeatedly, staying up very late, avoiding asking colleagues for input

Therapist: When we look at all five areas together, we can see how they influence each other. Changing one area (for example, the thoughts or the behaviors) can help break the cycle.

IDENTIFYING KEY NEGATIVE AUTOMATIC THOUGHTS

Therapist: From the diary and what you've told me, two thoughts seem to come up very strongly and frequently. Let's write them down:

1. "If I make a mistake, they will think I'm incompetent."
2. "I have to be perfect or they will finally see that I'm not good enough."

Therapist: Which of these feels strongest or most painful right now?

Client: The second one — "I have to be perfect or they will see I'm not good enough." That one feels very true and heavy.

BEGINNING COGNITIVE RESTRUCTURING

Therapist: Let's gently look at this thought: "I have to be perfect or they will see I'm not good enough." On a scale of 0–100, how much do you believe this right now?

Client: About 80%.

Therapist: Okay. What evidence do you have that supports this thought?

Client: I've seen people get criticized for small mistakes. I was once told in a review that one small error affected the whole impression.

Therapist: Good. Now, what evidence might go against it — even small pieces of evidence?

Client: (thinking for a while) Most of my work is actually good. I've been promoted twice. My current manager has given me positive feedback overall. Even when I made small mistakes before, the projects still succeeded.

Therapist: That's helpful. If we were to create a more balanced thought, what could it be?

Client: Maybe something like: "I don't have to be perfect to be competent. Making small mistakes doesn't mean I'm not good enough overall."

Therapist: Excellent. If you believed this balanced thought 100%, how would that change how you feel and what you do?

Client: I think I would feel less pressure and maybe not stay up until 1 AM checking everything.

HOMEWORK ASSIGNMENT

Therapist: For this week, I'd like you to continue the daily diary, and add one new task:

1. Continue the mood + thought diary every day
2. For the thought "I have to be perfect or they will see I'm not good enough," write down at least 2 pieces of evidence for and 2 pieces against it (we can review them next session)
3. Try one small behavioral change: When preparing something important, deliberately stop checking after a reasonable time (set a timer if needed) and notice what happens.

SESSION SUMMARY & FEEDBACK

Therapist: Today we reviewed your diary, built a fuller 5-area formulation, identified your key negative automatic thoughts, and started gently challenging one of them. What felt most useful?

Client: The 5-area model helped me see everything together. And writing down evidence against the "I have to be perfect" thought made it feel a bit less true.

Therapist: That's great progress. Any questions or anything you want to focus on more next time?

Client: No, this was good. I'll try the homework.

POST-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

- Client completed homework well and showed good understanding of patterns from the diary.
- 5-area formulation developed collaboratively — very useful for client.
- Key negative automatic thought identified and initial cognitive restructuring started.
- Client responded well to Socratic questioning and was able to generate balanced evidence.
- Homework clearly understood and client motivated.
- Next session: Review new homework, continue cognitive restructuring on core belief, introduce worry time technique if appropriate.

Disclaimer: This is a completely fictional but realistic simulation created solely for educational and AI training purposes. It does not represent any real person or therapy.